

The Death of Laughter

A desperate novelist plays with the middle class morality around sex and family



FAMILY PLANNING
by KARAN MAHAJAN
Rupa
Price: Rs 395
Pages: 218

| By Geeta Doctor |

Heaven knows we as a nation of a billion plus and still counting slobs could do with a sense of humour. Karan Mahajan sets himself the task with a grim determination that makes one think of a farmer lashing a pair of buffaloes and twisting their tail with a certain sadistic glee that could pass for comic action if it were not so debased. It's a zero sum satire that nevertheless has a certain manic energy. The buffaloes keep getting up and plodding through the circumlocutions of a plot that Mahajan has carefully contrived to keep our nose on track.

Like the different suitors who have been popping up at the swayamvar of our own bionic babe Rakhi Sawant, the plot revolves around certain key emotional triggers. Sex. Family. Destiny. These are the three new faces on the Ashoka pillar of the Indian middle class morality. By making these images revolve around the persona of his main character Rakesh Ahuja, a would be engineer who's become the Minister for Urban Development in New Delhi, he adds the fourth element, Power. Like

Rakhi Sawant, Mahajan varies his pitch from being achingly coy in some episodes and rampantly predatory at others, so as to tempt the reader with a certain knowing suggestiveness, that turns out to be as fake as the moment of truth on Reality TV.

The innocence if it can be called that comes from the travails of Arjun, the minister's eldest son, who is 16 and going through the usual adolescent frenzies such as the acne scarring his face and the girl tormenting his spare moments riding a bus to school that are generally associ-

ated with the age. So nothing special to be had here, except that being the son of a prominent citizen of Delhi and the first son of a dad who has gone on to produce 13 other siblings after him, Arjun is haunted by a certain anxiety about the reproductory process.

Living in the Ahuja residence, spacious and fully funded by the largesse of the government in a manner that would make Lalu Prasad envious, Arjun is close not only to the seat of power, but to the heat of his father's lust for the woman whom he can only take in those times when she is heavily pregnant. Mahajan is so horribly crude in his depiction of Mrs Ahuja and her

various bovine-like attributes, as he is to references to what we shall politely describe as the minority community of north India, that we can only say, if this is humour lets have old-fashioned contempt.

Maybe, this is because Arjun, due to a twist in the plot, is required to suffer from foreskin anxiety. That is to say that he's had to wait till he's 16 to be told by his dad, in one of those dad and son chats, that no Indian father would dare have that his penis is different from that of other members of the Ahuja family because? Here we must leave the would-be reader to make his or her own de-

ductions based on a closer reading of the book.

Is this funny or unbearably twee? Aside from such moments, Arjun has a way of using phrases such as "Sayonara Baby!" and throwing in nuggets of information about fading pop icons such as Bryan Adams and the *Summer of '69*, while going into embarrassing details about how to form a boy band in Delhi, just to impress a girl, the same bus-going chick. There's also a four-page sequence on how to chat a girl up while dying to take a leak. What can one say to all this, except there's no dick like a hick? ■

SAURABH SINGH

